

PeaceHealth Insights

Data Collection Methodology & Research Ethics Statement

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1. Purpose and Scope

PeaceHealth Insights is a digital tool designed to help humanitarian, peacebuilding, and public-health organizations understand how conflict and instability affect the mental and physical well-being of civilian populations. It allows individuals to self-report indicators such as stress, anxiety, sleep quality, exposure to conflict-related events, displacement status, and access to basic needs on a fully voluntary and anonymous basis.

This document describes the current data collection methodology, the safeguards in place, and — transparently — the safeguards that are still being developed before the platform is used for any large-scale or field deployment. It is intended to give partner organizations a clear, honest basis for evaluating a potential pilot collaboration.

2. Current Development Stage

PeaceHealth Insights is presently a functioning prototype (Minimum Viable Product). It has been tested for technical functionality — multi-language support, data submission, and secure cloud storage — but has not yet undergone formal review by an independent research ethics board (IRB) or equivalent committee. Any use involving real respondents in active conflict settings should occur only within a supervised pilot, as described in Section 6, and not as an unsupervised public deployment.

3. Data Collected

The questionnaire collects the following categories of information:

- Demographic indicators: age range, gender, country, city/province
- Well-being indicators: stress, anxiety, depression, sleep quality (1–10 self-report scales)
- Physical symptoms: headache, stomach pain
- Conflict exposure: type of conflict-related event experienced that day (e.g., airstrike, explosion, utility outage, direct threat, none)
- Situational indicators: current displacement status, access to basic needs (water, food, medicine, communication), contact with family
- Psychosocial indicators: perceived safety, social support, hope for the future
- An optional open-text comment

No names, contact details, government ID numbers, or precise geolocation are collected at any point. "City/Province" is entered as free text at the respondent's discretion and is the most granular location data gathered.

4. Informed Consent

Before accessing the questionnaire, every respondent will be shown a consent screen (in their selected language) that discloses, in plain language:

- That participation is voluntary and can be stopped at any time without consequence
- What data is collected and why
- That no personally identifying information is requested
- Who will have access to the aggregated data (the partner organization and the platform administrator)
- That the respondent may decline to answer any individual question

Respondents must actively confirm ("I understand and agree to participate") before the form becomes available. This consent step is described in Section 8 as an item currently being added to the application.

5. De-identification and Data Minimization

The platform is designed around data minimization: only the fields listed in Section 3 are collected, and no field maps directly to a specific individual. Because self-reported city/province and free-text comments could, in principle, combine with other public information to narrow down a respondent's identity in a small community, the following practices are recommended for any pilot:

- Aggregate and report findings at the regional level rather than the city level when sample sizes are small
- Review free-text responses before any external sharing and redact any details that could identify a person or exact location
- Avoid collecting data in contexts where the respondent pool is small enough that answers could be attributed to a specific individual

6. Data Storage and Security

Data is currently stored in a Google Sheet accessible only via a dedicated Google Cloud service account with narrowly scoped permissions (edit access to a single spreadsheet, no broader account access). Access credentials are stored as encrypted secrets within the hosting platform (Streamlit Community Cloud) and are not exposed in source code or version control.

Aspect	Current Implementation
Hosting	Streamlit Community Cloud (application) + Google Sheets (data store)
Access control	Single service account, editor-only, scoped to one spreadsheet
Credential storage	Encrypted secrets manager; not committed to source control
Transport security	HTTPS/TLS for all client-server communication
Data retention	Retained indefinitely unless a partner organization specifies a deletion schedule

For any pilot handling data from populations in active conflict zones, the recommended enhancement — before scale-up — is migration to a dedicated database with row-level access logging and a defined data retention/deletion policy agreed with the partner organization.

7. Data Use and Sharing

Aggregated, de-identified data may be shared with the partner organization for the agreed research or programmatic purpose stated in the pilot agreement. Data will not be sold, used for advertising, or shared with any third party outside the scope agreed with the partner organization.

8. Roadmap: Safeguards In Progress

The following items are in active development and are disclosed here for transparency:

- In-app informed consent screen (before the questionnaire is shown)
- Plain-language data-use disclosure embedded in the app itself
- Formal IRB / ethics committee review, to be pursued jointly with an academic or institutional partner before any large-scale deployment
- Migration from spreadsheet storage to a dedicated, access-logged database for any pilot beyond small-scale testing

9. Recommended Pilot Framework

Given the above, the recommended path for any partner organization is a small-scale, time-boxed pilot (4–6 weeks) with a limited number of respondents in a setting the partner organization already works in, with the partner organization's own field staff overseeing consent and data collection procedures. This allows both parties to evaluate the tool's usefulness and refine safeguards before any wider use is considered.

10. Contact

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